

Thursday 18 July 2024

Meeting Communiqué

Commonwealth, state and territory agriculture ministers met in person in Brisbane on Thursday 18 July 2024 for the second Agriculture Ministers' Meeting (AMM) of the year.

AMM 02/2024 was chaired by the Australian Minister for Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry, Senator the Hon Murray Watt. Ministers welcomed the new AMM Member for Tasmania, the Hon Jane Howlett MP and thanked the Hon Jo Palmer MLC for her contribution during her time as Tasmanian Minister for Primary Industries and Water.

Biosecurity

Australian high pathogenicity avian influenza (HPAI) outbreaks

Ministers discussed the serious outbreaks of H7 HPAI in Victoria, New South Wales, and the Australian Capital Territory, noting that it is the most significant avian disease incursion in Australia on record.

The Australian Chief Veterinary Officer, Dr Beth Cookson, briefed Ministers on the HPAI situation and provided details of biosecurity response efforts that remain underway in the three jurisdictions where detections have occurred.

Ministers recognised the challenges of responding to biosecurity incursions of this scale, given the costs to industry and the Commonwealth, state and territory governments, and expressed their commitment to strong and immediate action given the ongoing impact on the poultry and related industries, domestic supply chains and international trade.

Ministers welcomed new investments by the Commonwealth to strengthen biosecurity preparedness and combat the threat of H5 HPAI, and agreed on the need for a national, holistic approach to further this work, given the likely significant impacts of the virus on agriculture and our natural environment.

Ministers agreed to convene a national H5 preparedness exercise in the near future and to promote greater collaboration between agriculture, environment and health portfolios in their jurisdictions to better manage the risk of potential future HPAI incursions.

National Biosecurity Strategy

Ministers discussed the importance of a strong and resilient biosecurity system. Ministers received an update on the implementation of the National Biosecurity Strategy – our strategic roadmap for Australia's biosecurity system over the next 10 years.

Plant property identification

Ministers noted work underway through the National Biosecurity Committee to inform considerations on property identification arrangements for major Australian agricultural plant production sectors.

Cost of Living

Ministers recognised the severity of cost of living pressures for all Australians and noted the range of measures being implemented to address competition issues, including in the agricultural supply chain. Ministers noted the positive changes for producers arising from the Commonwealth's review of the Food and Grocery Code of Conduct. Ministers reiterated the need to ensure producers are treated fairly and receive appropriate remuneration for their hard work.

Agriculture Sustainability

Ministers discussed how new measures in the 2024-25 Federal Budget and state and territory budgets support initial emission reduction efforts in the agriculture and land sectors, and opportunities for ongoing collaboration in the design and implementation of new and existing measures.

Farm productivity and profitability and a genuine partnership between government and industry will remain driving forces of the sector's contribution to Australia's net zero transition. The Commonwealth's Agriculture and Land Sectoral Plan is progressing with its aim to position the sector to reduce emissions and build carbon stores in tandem with adapting to climate change.

Drought and Dry Seasonal Conditions

Ministers provided an update on work being undertaken in their jurisdictions to prepare for and respond to drought and dry seasonal conditions, including the provision of Commonwealth and state and territory support to drought-affected farmers.

Ministers noted work is well-advanced towards finalising a new five-year National Drought Agreement between the Commonwealth, State, and Territory governments.

National Statement for First Nations in Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry.

Ministers were briefed on progress in developing Australia's First National Statement on Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry. This statement seeks to build a strong partnership between governments and First Nations communities to lift First Nation's engagement in the agriculture, fisheries, and forestry sectors.

Key themes arising from Phase 1 consultation sessions undertaken nationally in May and June 2024 were presented to Ministers. The National Statement Taskforce is working on these themes and progressing further consultation to develop the statement as required.

Viticulture and Wine Sector Working Group Update

Ministers noted the progress of the Viticulture and Wine Sector Working Group to date. Ministers agreed the Working Group complete its final report by the end of July and provide to Agriculture Ministers out of session, before working on implementation of recommendations.

Ministers welcomed the strong recovery in wine exports to China since trade suspensions were lifted. Ministers noted the new work underway to support the sector since the Working Group's establishment, including the Commonwealth Government's \$3.5 million Grape and Wine Sector long-term viability package to build demand, provide better data for growers to make decisions and diversify, and investigate competition and regulatory issues.

Ministers noted the independent report prepared by Professor Kym Anderson on "[The current wine crisis: Ways forward in Australia's wine regions](#)." Ministers agreed to make Professor Anderson's report publicly available to assist industry in future planning.

Workforce

Minister Watt provided a short update on the Regional Migration Discussion Paper currently out for consultation and the extended phase-in of the minimum hours requirement for short term workers in the Pacific Australia labour Mobility (PALM) scheme. This responds to concerns from the horticulture sector.

Wild dogs and dingoes

Ministers discussed the impacts of wild dogs and dingoes on agriculture and noted various jurisdictional approaches to addressing these impacts.

Next meeting

Ministers agreed to meet next virtually on 1 November 2024.

Ministerial attendees

- Australian Government (Chair): Senator the Hon Murray Watt, Minister for Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry and Minister for Emergency Management
- Australian Capital Territory: Rebecca Vassarotti, MLA, Minister for the Environment
- New South Wales: Hon Tara Moriarty MLC, Minister for Agriculture, Minister for Regional New South Wales, and Minister for Western New South Wales
- Northern Territory: Hon Mark Monaghan MLA, Minister for Agribusiness and Fisheries
- Queensland: Hon Mark Furner MP, Minister for Agricultural Industry Development and Fisheries, and Minister for Rural Communities
- South Australia: Hon Clare Scriven MLC, Minister for Primary Industries and Regional Development, and Minister for Forest Industries
- Tasmania: Hon Jane Howlett MP, Minister for Primary Industries and Water

- Victoria: Hon Michaela Settle MP, Parliamentary Secretary for Agriculture; Parliamentary Secretary for Regional Development, was a proxy for Hon Ros Spence MP, Minister for Agriculture
- Western Australia: Hon Jackie Jarvis MLC, Minister for Agriculture and Food; Forestry; Small Business.

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/about/news/stay-informed/communiques/ag-ministers-forum-jul-2024>